Where Have All the Lightning Bugs Gone?

By Louis Catron

A Girl is reading a book, with other books on the ground next to her. Boy enters – embarrassed, shy – he tries to catch her eye. No luck. Finally he gets up his nerve to speak to her. But the girl speak first without looking at him.

GIRL: *(Very composed)* No, I ***don't*** know what time it is. Yes it ***is*** a very good book. No, I ***don't*** have a match. And yes, I ***am*** waiting for someone.

BOY: *(Amazed)* What?

GIRL: *(Blasé)* My boyfriend, who is six foot six. He plays football for the Jets. He weighs over two hundred pounds and this monster will be here any moment. So good-bye.

BOY: Wow! *(In awe)* You didn't even look up. How'd you know I was here?

GIRL: *(Still engrossed in the book)* I'm psychic.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Things were so much simpler when we were kids.*
ACTRESS: *Making friends was a cinch—recess, lunchtime . . . even riding your bike in your own neighborhood.*
ACTOR: *As you get older, making new friends isn't as easy!*
ACTRESS: *But, since maintaining inter-human connections is important,*
ACTOR: *And you may someday need people to serve as character witnesses*
ACTRESS: *This selection may be just the guidance you need!*
TOGETHER: *Where Have All the Lightning Bugs Gone? By Louis Catron*

BOY: I mean, this is open range. No fences. So how come you've tried to put up barbed wire, partner?

GIRL: *(A bit taken aback)* Barbed wire?

BOY: You and me, we're a-gonna have a shoot-out. *(He is a cowboy with clanking spurs, a big sombrero and two heavy guns)* Ain't nobody a-goin' put up no fence nohow on this

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here range, pardner. No, sir. It's noon, see, and I'm a-walkin' down this dusty road right a-toward you. Now. Be you goin' draw at me? *(He tenses)* Make your play. *(He draws, get shot, falls)* Ahhhh! *(Gasps)* Got me. *(Crawls toward her)* I reckon I'm only the West's . . . second . . . fastest gun.

GIRL: *(Laughs)* You got what you deserve, cowboy.

BOY: *(Dying)* I'm a-goin' fast. But . . . 'fore I pass on . . . to that . . . great blue range up yonder . . . tell me: What's the name . . . of . . . that fast gun critter who shot me cold?

GIRL: Kate.

BOY: *(Drops cowboy character; sits up)* Kate? *(Seriously)* Kate. That's a very attractive name. *(He suddenly becomes the cowboy again and sprawls to the ground)* All right, Kate. You done me in. No hard feelings. *(He dies. Motionless)*

GIRL: *(Mournfully)* He's dead. And I never knew the poor feller's name. He'll have an unmarked stone, up there on Boot Hill.

BOY: *(Alive; jumps up to his knees)* William.

GIRL: *(Contemplates the name)* William. Will. Willy. Bill. *(Sudden insight)* Billy the Kid?

BOY: *(Drawling)* That's what some folk call me. *(Girls suddenly becomes awkward and goes back to reading her book. She turns her body away from the Boy)*

GIRL: Okay. That's enough. *(Not looking at him)* I knew you were going to ask me a question. Try to talk with me. Start a conversation so you could pick me up.

BOY: *(Earnestly)* Yeah? *(Boy springs to his feet and become a strong man in the circus, flexing his muscles, posing) (In a circus barker's manner)* Yes, sir, ladies and gentlemen, the Strongest Man alive. Watch him pick up that beautiful girl, using only one hand. Come one, come all. Only one thin dime and he'll show you amazing feats. *(Girl laughs – Boy drops strong man character)* Kate's a nice name. *(Trying hard to remember; speaking in a Shakespearean tone)* They call you Kate that do speak of you? Bonnie Kate, the prettiest Kate in all Christendom?

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GIRL: *(Impressed)* That's pretty good.

BOY: But what light? 'Tis the East, and Kate is the sun. *(Dropping Shakespearean voice)* No, that doesn't work so well.

GIRL: Do you know Shakespeare?

BOY: Sure. He runs that little pizza parlor on Eighth.

GIRL: *(Not laughing)* Ho ho ho.

BOY: Do you?

GIRL: *(Loftily)* Of course. *(Impressed with her own intelligence and lifting the book she is reading)* This is about him. . . You've got a good approach, I'll say that for you. And I've heard a lot of lines, believe me.

BOY: *(Mock outrage)* Line?

GIRL: Sure *(Generously)* It's good. I usually don't speak to stranger.

BOY: *(More outraged)* Well, you're not psychic after all. All that stuff about time, and a book, and a boyfriend. Huh. You were just putting me on. Listen. I wasn't going to ask you any of those things. What do you think of that?

GIRL: *(Kindly)* What were you going to say?

BOY: *(Becomes TV announcer; microphone in hand)* This is your Man on the Street, friends *(Big smile which switches on and off)* And here I am, out in the park on this beautiful day, talking to Miss Kate Brown.

GIRL: My name isn't Brown.

BOY: *(Ignoring her)* As you know, friends out there in wonderful TV land, each day WXX-TV asks the big jackpot question. If Miss Kate Brown knows the answer, she wins our special prize. How about that, Miss Kate Brown?

GIRL: Matter of fact, my name isn't Kate, either.

BOY: *(Dropping character; sotto voice)* That's okay. My name isn't William. *(TV announcer)* Now here it comes, Miss Sally Barrows. Are you ready?

GIRL: *(A giggling, simpering Southern belle, using a fan)* Oh, Ah do declare, Ah gets so

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fearful in front of that camera that y'all got over there. Ah just know Ah'll forget.

BOY: The question is – are you ready? -- it is "What ever happened to all the lightning bugs?" You have fifteen seconds, Miss Sally Barrows of Landogoshen, Alabama. *(begins watching the time)*

GIRL: Oh, dear, Oh, dear. What's the question?

BOY: *(Pompously)* We just asked it, ma'am.

GIRL: Really, Honey, would y'all ask it just one more time? Ah promise to listen real close, heah?

BOY: *(Irritated)* Are you trying to cheat? We told you: fifteen seconds. Now you're trying to cheat for more time.

GIRL: *(Big business with eyelashes)* Honey, Ah never would cheat you.

BOY: *(Dropping character; speaking confidentially)* I know you wouldn't. That's why I wanted to talk to you. *(TV announcer again)* Well, friends, it looks like this young lady blew it. Bang! This has been your roving reporter, Anthony Knight. Good bye. *(Boy turns to leave)*

GIRL: *(No longer the Southern belle; a bit offended)* I didn't think that question was so good. Anyhow, I really didn't hear it.

BOY: *(turning around.)* That doesn't make sense. First you said the question was no good. Then you said you didn't hear it. *(Boy has gotten quite close to the Girl, his lips quite close to hers. He now kisses her. Girl seems to respond for an instant Then . . .)*

GIRL: Quit that! *(Angry) (Boy moves behind her. He is perfectly still, his back toward her)* What made you think you could get away with that? You've got nerve. *(Girl begins to leave. Boy doesn't speak. Girl becomes more uncertain. She pauses then decides to stay.) (Gently)* Please put out your hand. *(Boy stretches his hand out slowly behind him, toward her. Girl stretches out her hand. Their fingers touch. They don't look at each other).* Thank you. Look, I don't want to leave. I want to stay.

BOY: *(Facing her)* Why'd you do that?

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GIRL: *(Embarrassed)* It's so hard to talk to people. Touching hands: that helps.

BOY: *(Thinking)* Maybe that's why it gets harder. Talking, I mean. When we get older. Remember how we used to play? When we were kids. It was easier then because we didn't mind touching each other.

GIRL: We didn't even think about it. Maybe we'd touch, playing some game, and we never thought about what it might mean. Now though . . .

BOY: It was easier.

GIRL: Things get more complicated when you get older. There's always that suspicion. You know what I mean. All the pawing, grabbing. . . Did you have fun when you were a kid?

BOY: *(Reflectively)* We used to do a lot of things that I liked. In the evenings, when it was dark, we'd play flashlight hide and seek.

GIRL: So'd we. There'd be a dozen kids from the neighborhood.

BOY: The streetlights were sort of half-hidden by the trees.

GIRL: *(Taking up the narrative)* And we'd hide. Behind trees. Or under a hedge. And whoever was IT would try to find us. *(Takes Boy's hand and leads him to a hiding place)*

BOY: But IT couldn't find you and me.

GIRL: Because we'd find a place where we both could hide. Together. *(Whisper together in their secret hiding place until Boy breaks away)*

BOY: Being a kid wasn't always fun. Someone was always around. An adult, trying to rush us. *(He gets up. He is a menacing night watchman with a thick voice)* Awright, youse kids. Watcha doin', lyin' on the grass like that?

GIRL: *(Young, innocent, frightened)* Nothin'. Honest, we were just hidin' here.

BOY: *(The watchman)* Hidin'? That ain't what it looks like to me. Whatcha doin', you there boy? I seen you around before, ain't I?

GIRL: *(Indignant, but still frightened)* You leave him alone!

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BOY: *(The watchman)* Go on, boy. You get outta here. I'll take little Miss Smartie Pants home myself.

GIRL: I'll tell my father on you! He's the mayor of this town, and he'll fix you! So there!

BOY: *(Dropping the watchman character and laughing)* You really showed him!

GIRL: *(She takes boy's hand and pulls him back down to the ground then continues as if there had been no interruption)* We used to catch lightning bugs. Put them in a glass jar. God's own moon bugs. Do you come here often?

BOY: Never. You?

GIRL: First time.

BOY: It must be Fate.

GIRL: It was that question about fireflies. That really got me. How did you think up that one?

BOY: *(Earnest)* I've always wondered. There used to be so many. And wrens. Other little birds. And butterflies. The big ones.

GIRL: *(Shaking her head)* What happened to them?

BOY: *(Jumps up to become a professor lecturing)* Very well, students. Today's lecture topic concerns the question of the demise of certain small living things. Specifically, the nocturnal soft-bodied beetle.

GIRL: *(Taking notes. Raises hand)* Professor? Sir, would you be so kind as to spell that?

BOY: B – U – G.

GIRL: *(Gushing)* Oh, thank you so much, professor.

BOY: *(Straightening tie, brushing hair back)* Now. This insect is often called a glow worm. But it isn't a worm, of course. It is called by some, a glow fly. Or a fire fly. This lightning bug has an organ at the tip of the abdomen which produces a soft light, a glow. *(Rocking back and forth)* Any questions? *(Girl raises hand again)* Yes?

GIRL: You said you were going to tell us the rationale behind the mysterious disappearance of this lovely insect.

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BOY: *(Loosening tie)* Since my attention is drawn to a carless oversight on my part, allow me to finish. The salient point is that they're gone. The roses of our summer die. The glowworms of our youth are killed. And how? *(Pause, then assuming a poetic air)* What is this that thou hast done to innocence? With freeways and speeding cars, thee assassinated the gentle butterfly and the warm glow worm. *(Sadly)* They fly no more.

GIRL: *(Dropping character)* Is that what happened?

BOY: *(Dropping character)* That's my theory. I used to have a job in a car wash. The front ends smeared with bugs. Never mosquitoes. And not ugly hornets. *(Sadly)* Only the beautiful things get killed.

GIRL: *(Softly)* I know.

BOY: Love get killed, not hate.

GIRL: Yes *(moves in closer to Boy and takes his hand)*

BOY: Nice people, not the other kind.

GIRL: *(Sigh)* Only the beautiful.

BOY: And the bad thing is that I don't know what to do about it. *(Girl rests her head on Boy's shoulder as scene ends)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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